



power delivery. This leads to instant acceleration off the throttle, super quick overtaking and slick fast runs whenever you get an empty stretch. The electric drive is paired with a two-speed synchro-shift Steptronic transmission, and the engine is mated with a six-speed Steptronic gearbox, which is fast, smooth and, with short ratios, responsive.

The real deal about the i8's technology lies with its powertrain. Switching the car on makes no noise, and the car sets off in electric drive mode. Additionally, it gets brake energy regeneration which also charges the battery, and the intelligent controller module tunes the power delivery according to how you drive. When you're cruising along, power is mostly drawn from the electric motor with the engine sitting at idle. When you shift to Sport, however, the electric motor pulses assistive power bursts to the engine's power delivery, and all of the 362bhp is delivered in a linear, smooth manner which is quite impressive.

You get paddle shifters, of course, and the car pushes all the way up the rev counter, with the electric motor assisting the upper end of the power delivery. The hybrid powertrain is intelligent, and offers dynamic driving range calculation depending on how you brake, and how much energy the i8 can regenerate through its drive. Interestingly, while Eco Pro and Comfort get a rocker switch for being selected, there are no buttons for Sport mode, and instead you need to flick the gear selector into Sport for the digital instrument cluster to glow red. The BMW i8 also filters in engine noise to amplify the sporty appeal of the i8, and you do hear a nice, refined grumble when you poke the accelerator hard.

The technology package extends further with a high definition augmented Head-Up Display (HUD). This high-res HUD has been present across BMW's M Sport line of cars, and shows the digital speedo, music playback, navigation arrows and distance to turns, and phone control. It also

blinks prompts for the driver assistive systems, and alerts when you step beyond speed limits, making it better equipped than BMW's standard line. The driver assistance package includes adaptive cruise control with braking, pedestrian alert system and proximity alert, where the car maintains a safe distance by itself from cars ahead. It does not, however, get a lane maintenance system.

The iDrive infotainment system does not get gesture controls, but is adorned with new animations to make it look different from its other trims. It gets all its standard features including the severely outdated BMW ConnectedDrive apps, a jazzed-up navigation unit, Harman/Kardon speakers with audio tuning, and ambient lighting in three shades with various configurations of blue, orange and white. The front seat adjustments are fully electric, and the specially contoured sport seats are quite adept at holding you in position even in twisty sections and with aggressive driving.

The BMW i8 handles supremely well, aided by its very low centre of gravity, a nicely weighted steering wheel that weighs up as you switch to Sport mode, and supremely stable four-wheel drive. You also get a new set of BMW LEDs, with DRLs, projector headlamps and LED tail lamps. However, it is not the most comfortable of cabins. The frameless scissor doors are incredibly fancy, but stepping into the car requires you to bend and somewhat slot yourself into the seats, and with the seat itself being so low, it takes a while to get adjusted to the seating position. This position, however, does help if you push the car hard through a winding stretch of straight lines and turns.

The BMW i8 is a one-of-a-kind experience, combining sublime performance and handling with a host of technologies that include its plug-in hybrid powertrain, augmented HUD, driver assistance systems and more. The BMW i8 is one for the future that is ahead of its time, at least in India. If the array of technology on board this car doesn't convince you of it, its design certainly will. The images in this article must have told you why. **A**